

Tonghua Li

📍 York, United Kingdom ✉ tonghua.li@york.ac.uk 🌐 tonghua-li.com

Research Interests

Constructivism, Political Discourse and Narratives, Ideas and Ideology, International Political Economy of Trade, US-China Relations, China in International Politics

Education

- Oct 2023 – present **University of York, PhD in Politics** – United Kingdom
Department of Politics and International Relations
- Supervisors: Prof. Tony Heron, Dr. Tomaz M. Fares
 - Thesis topic: The High Politics of Trade: Discourse, Strategic Response, and Legitimation in the Trump Era
- Sept 2022 – Sept 2023 **University of Glasgow, MSc in International Relations** – United Kingdom
School of Social and Political Sciences
- GPA: **Distinction (First Class Degree)**
 - Dissertation: Exploring the Role of NGOs in Governance from the Perspective of Chinese State-NGO relations
 - Supervisors: Prof. Jane Duckett, Dr. Neil Munro
- Sept 2018 – July 2022 **Lincoln University & Yunnan Agricultural University, BSc in Agricultural Economics** – China and New Zealand
International College
- GPA: 3.8/4.0 (Ranking: 1/90)
 - Graduation Project: An Analysis on the employment and settlement of peasant emigration in Yunlong County
- July 2019 – Aug 2019 **University of California, Berkeley, Summer School in US-China Relations** – United State

Professional Experience

- Apr 2026 – present **Lead Organizer, [Global China Studies Early Career Researcher Network](#)**
- Established and managed a global academic network for China studies, engaging 300+ scholars worldwide.
 - Organized a July 2026 annual conference engaging 70+ scholars worldwide, funded by the Faculty of Social Sciences at the University of York.
 - Coordinate regular webinars open to researchers from any institution worldwide.
- May 2024 – present **Seminar Tutor, University of York**
- Led seminars for 400+ undergraduate students, marked 500+ pieces of coursework, and provided academic support.
 - Teaching Modules:
Introduction to Global Politics (POL00015C, 2026-2027, Spring)
Global Challenges: From Theory to Practice (POL00012C, 2026-2027, 2025-2026, Autumn)
Research Skills and Project Design (ENV00048I, 2025-2026, Spring)
York Policy Lab (POL00016C, 2024-2025, Spring)
Introduction to Comparative Politics (POL00013C, 2024-2025, Autumn)

Oct 2023 – Nov 2025 **Researcher**, Stockholm Environment Institute

- Conducted research on food security and environmental sustainability in the context of US-China trade tensions, with a particular focus on the resilience of global food systems amid geopolitical crises.
- Participated in and organized academic activities for the Sustainable Consumption and Production Research Group, and contributed to co-authored reports and other research outputs.

June 2022 – Sept 2023 **Teaching Assistant**, Path Academy

- IELTS Writing and Speaking Tutor, providing feedback and tutoring to 50+ students.
- Involved in course preparation at the University of Pennsylvania. Assisted with literature review and data collection, and provided teaching assistant support in political thought and international relations theory.

Working Papers

- (Under Review) Li, T. (2026). "Trade, Power, and Discursive Instability: Trump's Trade Discourse as Political Practice." *New Political Economy*.
- (Under Review) Li, T. (2026). "The Configurational Politics of Trade Measures in Trump's Foreign Policy: US Political Conditions for Chinese Restraint." *The British Journal of Politics and International Relations*.
- (Under Review) Li, T., Yan, Z., and Fares, T. M. (2026). "Between Global Growth and Domestic Stability: Discursive Contestation in China's Food Security Governance." *Global Studies Quarterly*.
- (Forthcoming) Li, T., Heron, T., and Fares, T. M. (2027). "The Politics of Selective Green Legitimation in China-South America Agricultural Trade in the Trump 2.0 Era." *International Development Planning Review*.
- (Working) Li, T., (2026). *Water Politics Under Power Asymmetries: Discourse Practice and Resource Governance in the Mekong River*

Selected Conference Presentations

- Sept 2026 **The Configurational Politics of Trade Measures in Trump's Foreign Policy: US Political Conditions for Chinese Restraint**
(ECPR- European Consortium for Political Research 2026 General Conference, Kraków)
- June 2026 **Trade, Power, and Discursive Instability: Political Rationales in Trump's Trade Policy**
(PSA- Political Studies Association 2026 American Politics Summer Conference, Oxford)
- June 2026 **Between Global Growth and Domestic Stability: Discursive Contestation in China's Food Security Governance During the Fourteenth Five-Year Plan**
(BISA- British International Studies Association 2026 Conference, Brighton)
- Mar 2026 **Trade, Power, and Discursive Instability: Political Rationales in Trump's Trade Policy**
(ISA- International Studies Association 67th Annual Convention, Columbus)
- July 2025 **The Political Economy of Food Trade in the US-China Trade Dispute: Soybean and Biofuels Policy During Trump's First Term**
(PPE Society- London Annual Conference, King's College London)

Skills

Software: NVivo, Python, R, QGIS, SPSS, MS Office, Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Premiere Pro

Research Skills: Interviews, Discourse Analysis, Thematic Analysis, Geographic Information System Analysis

Languages: English (Fluent), Chinese (Native), Japanese (Basic)

Awards Scholarships and Grants

- 2023-2027 **CSC - University of York joint-funded PhD Scholarship – £133,650**
- April 2026 **University of York Faculty of Social Science PGR Community Fund – £1,500**
- April 2026 **University of York Open Research Awards – £400**
- March 2026 **European Consortium for Political Research Grant – £500**
- March 2022 **YAU University Level Scholarship (Top 5%)**
- December 2021 **First Prize in China FLTRP National English Speech Competition**
- Jan 2020 **YAU Outstanding Student (Top 1%)**
- Jan 2020 **First Place in the Volunteer English Speaking Competition of COP15, UN**

References

Prof. Tony Heron

- University of York, Department of Politics and International Relations
- Head of Department, Professor of Political Economy
- tony.heron@york.ac.uk

Dr. Tomaz M. Fares

- University of York, Department of Politics and International Relations
- Lecturer in International Relations
- tomaz.fares@york.ac.uk

Dr. Peg Murray-Evans

- University of York, Department of Politics and International Relations
- Lecturer in International Relations
- peg.murray-evans@york.ac.uk